ISSUE 61

OCTOBER 18, 2026

LAST WEEK IN TÜRKİYE

A weekly roundup of the top news and developments in Türkiye

MARCH 19 PLATFORM
UNITED FOR DEMOCRACY IN TÜRKİYE

Swipe

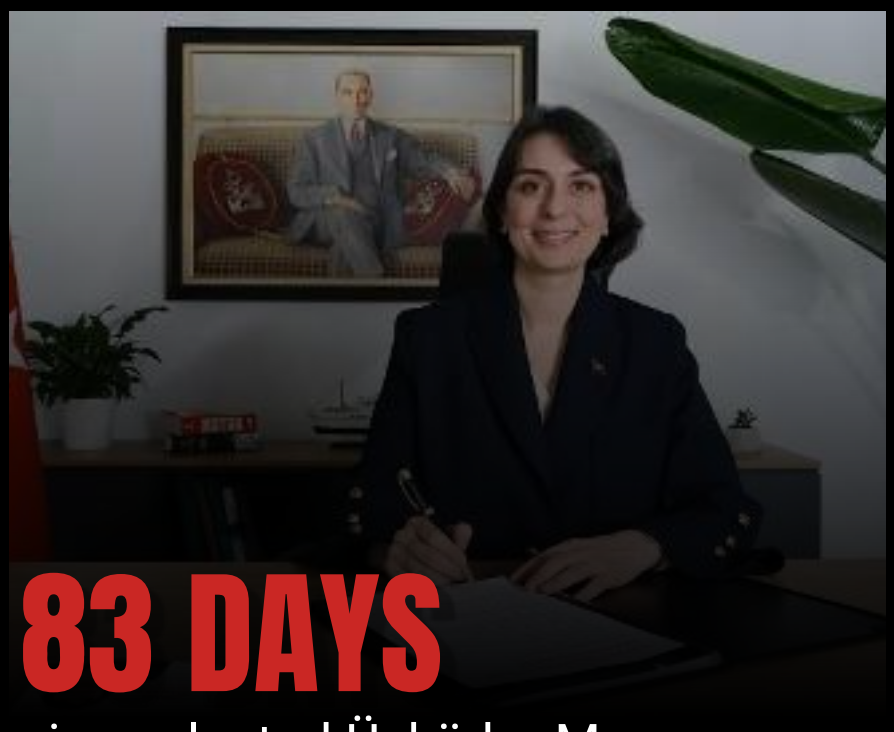
OCTOBER 18, 2026

REMINDERS BY NUMBERS



580 DAYS

since Istanbul Mayor and opposition preseidential candidate Ekrem İmamoğlu was jailed. His trial is still ongoing.



83 DAYS

since elected Üsküdar Mayor Sinem Dedetaş was jailed pending trial, despite not being convicted of any crime.



25 DAYS

since retired police officer Ali Şekeroğlu committed suicide during a protest over pensioners' financial struggles in front of the Constitutional Court



488 DAYS

since attorney Mehmet Pehlivan was arrested. He remains imprisoned despite the reported expiration of the maximum legal period for pretrial detention.



HALK TV STAFF DEFY GOVERNMENT TAKEOVER

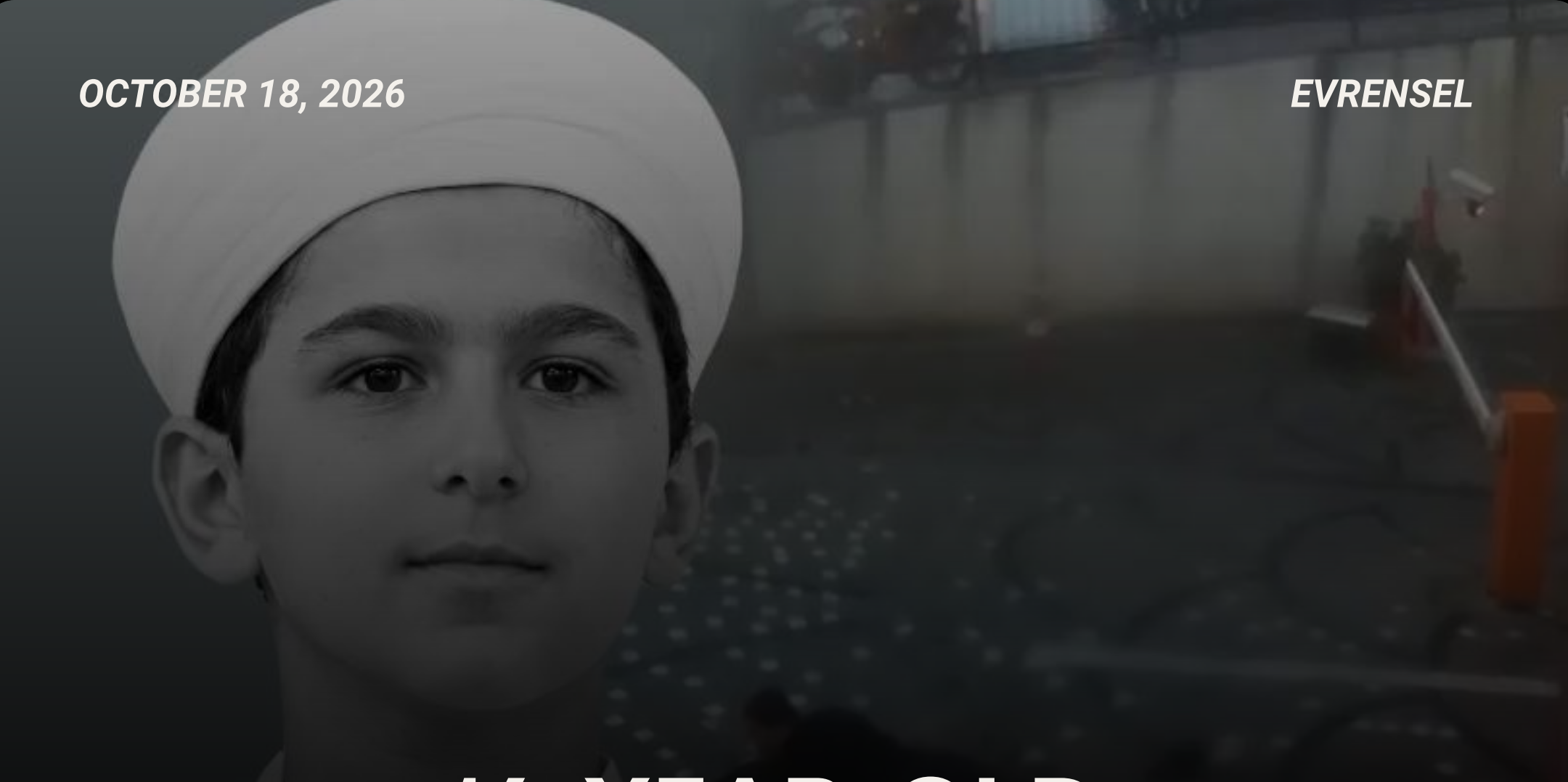
Following a police raid and the appointment of a state-appointed trustee, Halk TV, one of Türkiye's leading independent news channels, was forced off the air. Editor-in-chief Suat Toktaş and staff gathered in the studio to deliver a defiant message: "They seized our channel because they couldn't silence us. Journalism will not end." Toktaş described the takeover as an attack on the public's right to information, declaring, "What is really being blocked is your right to know."



OCTOBER 18, 2026

HISTORIC FLOODS DEVASTATE ISTANBUL: FOUR DEAD, FIVE MISSING

Istanbul experienced its heaviest rainfall since 1942 on October 15, with some areas receiving 272 millimeters of rain. At least four people died, including a worker who fell into a well during floodwater drainage operations in Beykoz. Five others were reported missing as search efforts continued. Emergency teams rescued 3,050 people trapped by rising waters, while seven injured residents received medical treatment. Schools were closed on October 16, and authorities announced financial assistance for flood victims.



14-YEAR-OLD ELECTROCUTED AT ALLEGEDLY ILLEGAL PARKING LOT IN ISTANBUL

Fourteen-year-old Mahmut Işıldak died from electrocution during heavy rainfall in Istanbul's Fatih district on October 14. The tragedy occurred at a parking lot reportedly operated illegally by the İsmailağa religious community, despite longstanding official awareness of its unauthorized status. According to reports, exposed electrical cables damaged by vehicles and the absence of a basic safety circuit breaker contributed to his death. The incident has raised serious questions about municipal oversight, negligence, and accountability for preventable deaths.

OCTOBER 18, 2026

BIANET



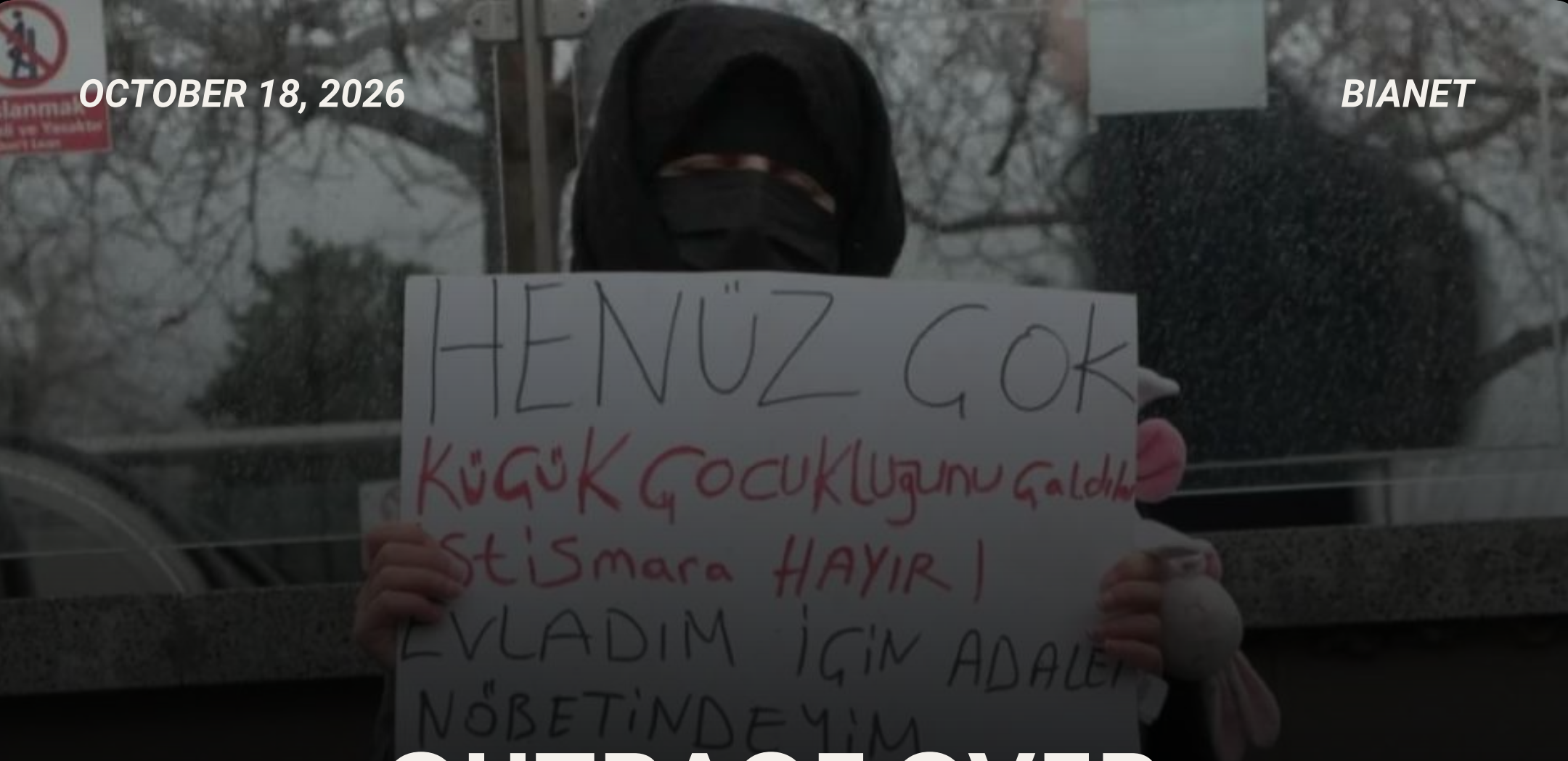
200 CAMPUS DOGS SEIZED IN NIGHTTIME POLICE OPERATION

Approximately 200 dogs cared for by students and animal rights activists at Ege University in İzmir were removed overnight by municipal teams accompanied by riot police. Students and academics protested the operation, with police reportedly using pepper spray against those resisting. Witnesses claimed campus lights were turned off and dogs were forcibly loaded into vehicles. “We have cared for these dogs like our own,” one resident said. Authorities have yet to disclose where the animals were taken, raising serious concerns about their welfare.



İZMIR RESIDENTS TAKE TO THE STREETS AFTER MIDNIGHT SEIZURE OF CAMPUS DOGS

Students, academics, and animal rights activists protested in İzmir after approximately 160 dogs cared for at Ege University were removed during a midnight operation involving municipal teams and riot police. Protesters alleged police violence, pepper spray use, and deliberate power cuts to prevent documentation. The dogs' whereabouts remain unknown. Activists criticized university rector Musa Alcı and Bornova Municipality, demanding accountability. "We will not allow our companions to be sent to their deaths," they declared, vowing to continue defending animal rights.



OUTRAGE OVER ACQUITTAL IN HIFA İKRA ABUSE CASE

Fatma Nur Çelik alleged that she was sexually abused as a child by Ayhan Şengüler, a Kuran'a Hizmet Foundation executive, and was forced to marry him. She later reported that their daughter, Hifa İkra, was sexually abused by him from the age of three. Despite medical reports and calls for his arrest, Şengüler remained free while the case proceeded. Fatma Nur repeatedly demanded justice outside the courthouse, warning, "If something happens to me, don't call it suicide." On March 2, 2026, she and eight-year-old Hifa were found dead by Istanbul's coast. On October 14, the court acquitted Şengüler, prompting outrage from women's rights groups, who vowed to continue seeking justice.

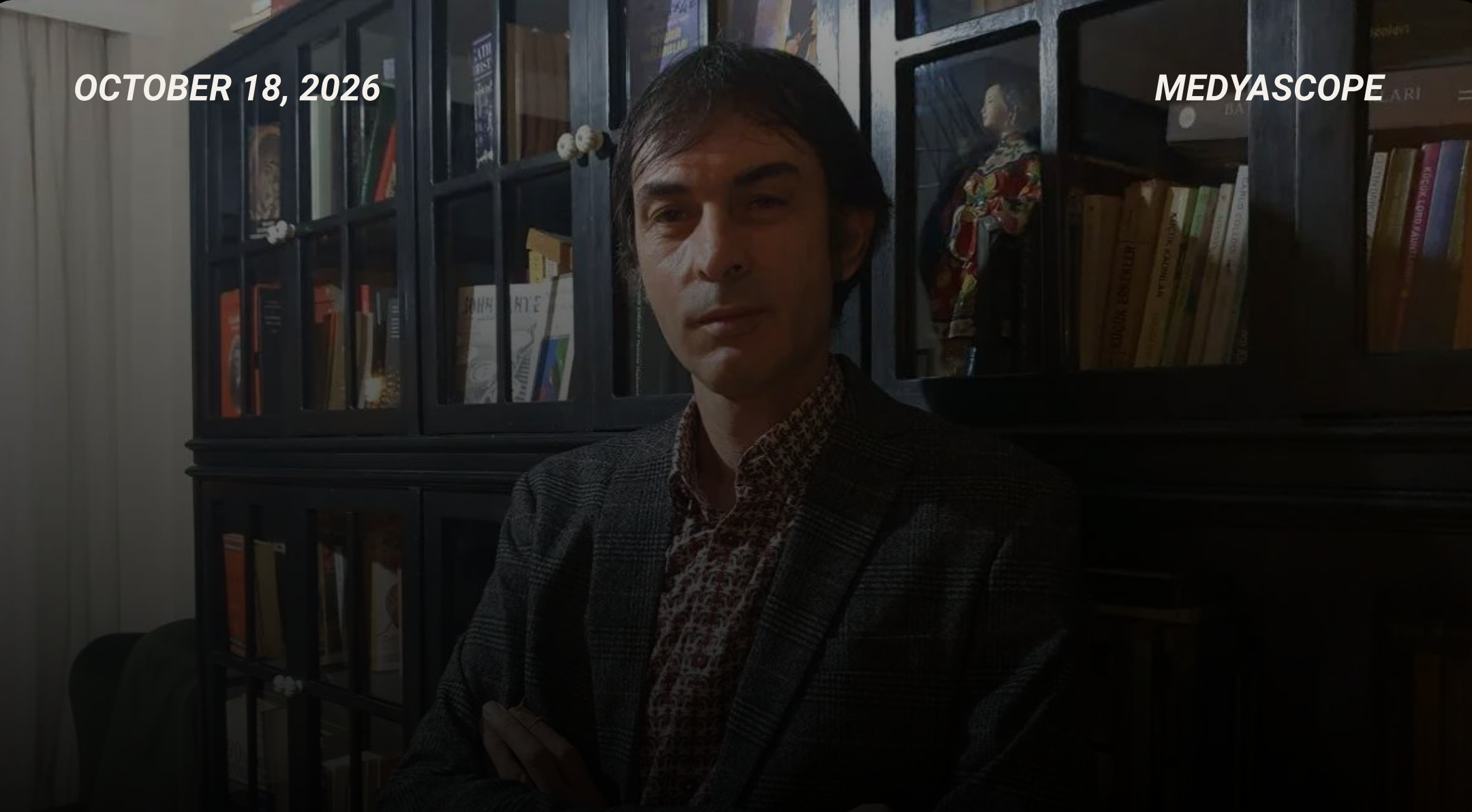


OCTOBER 18, 2026

BIANET

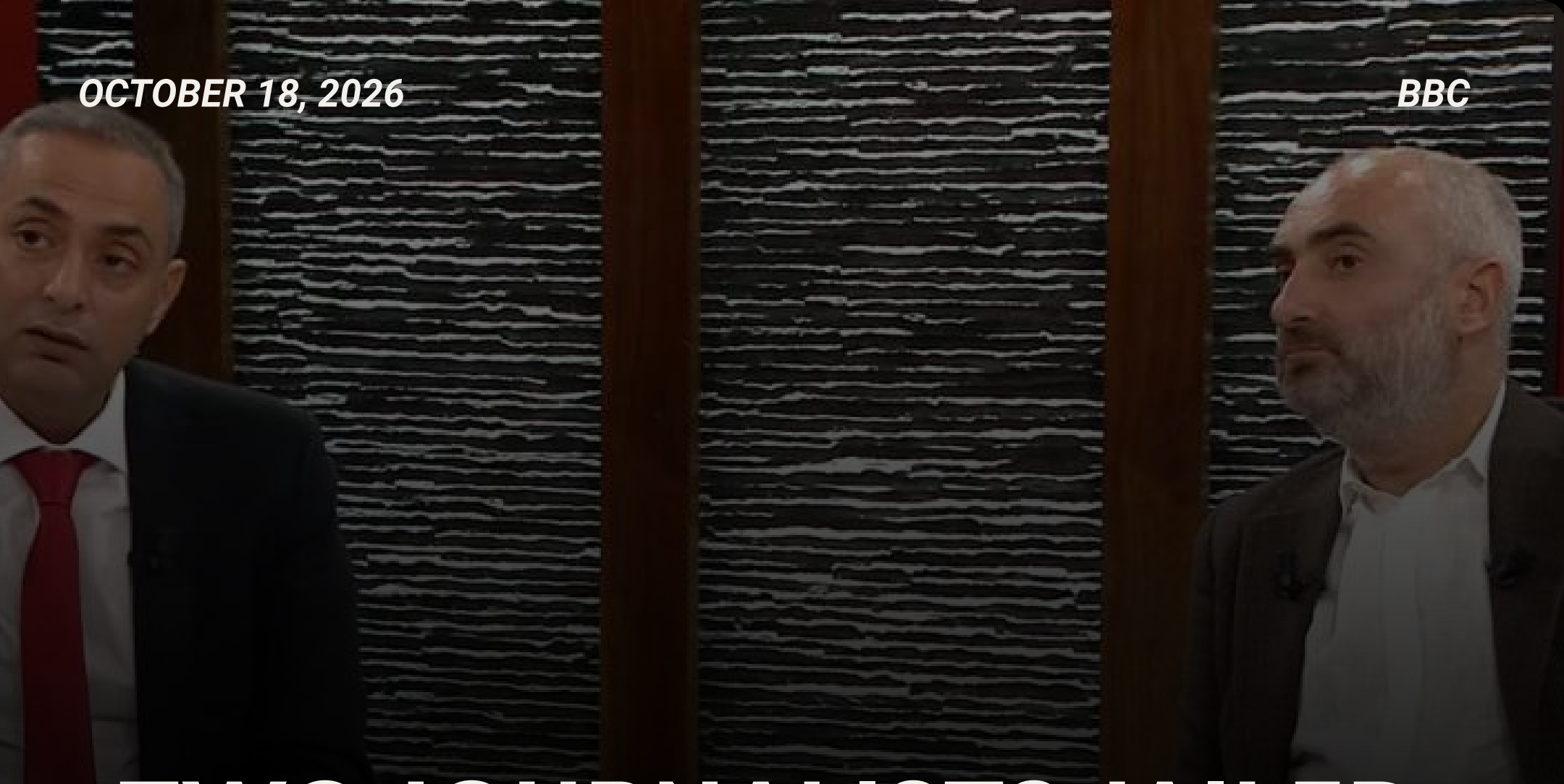
TWO YEARS WITHOUT ANSWERS: THE UNSOLVED DEATH OF ROJIN KABAIŞ

Two years after 21-year-old university student Rojin Kabaiş disappeared and was found dead near Lake Van, questions remain unanswered. Investigators identified six individuals near her last known location and drivers of 11 vehicles. Her phone data remains under examination. Although forensic reports listed drowning as the cause of death, women's rights organizations demand a transparent investigation, criticizing restrictions on case files. Students commemorated Rojin, while her father called for accountability. “Two years have passed. Where are the answers?” asked women's rights group EŞİK.



JOURNALIST DETAINED , LATER RELEASED UNDER JUDICIAL SUPERVISION

Journalist Bahadır Özgür was detained for allegedly “violating the confidentiality of an investigation” while reporting on Türkiye’s investment fund scandal. His X account, with 163,000 followers, was also ordered blocked. Özgür was released under judicial supervision, including a travel ban and reporting requirements. Following his release, he described the revolving door of journalists facing detention: “As I was leaving, Murat Ağırel was coming in.” He added, “I hope all imprisoned journalists will be released.”



OCTOBER 18, 2026

BBC

TWO JOURNALISTS JAILED, TWO PLACED UNDER HOUSE ARREST

Four Turkish journalists faced legal action over their reporting on alleged corruption involving public officials and investment funds. Sözcü editor Mustafa Balcı and journalist Şaban Sevinç were arrested on October 9 on charges of “publicly spreading misleading information.” Journalists İsmail Saymaz and Murat Ağırel were initially placed under judicial supervision but later ordered into house arrest following a prosecutorial appeal. Both denied wrongdoing. Ağırel defended his reporting, stating, “Reporting an allegation as an allegation does not mean presenting it as an established



TURKISH COURT REJECTS OSMAN KAVALA'S RELEASE DESPITE EUROPEAN HUMAN RIGHTS RULING

On October 13, an Istanbul court rejected imprisoned philanthropist Osman Kavala's requests for release and retrial following an August 25 ruling by the European Court of Human Rights (ECHR). The court argued that domestic legal remedies had not been exhausted and that international courts could not interfere with Türkiye's judicial sovereignty. It ordered the continued enforcement of Kavala's 2022 sentence, despite the ECHR ruling, raising renewed concerns over Türkiye's compliance with international human rights obligations.



AKP LAWMAKER BREAKS RANKS OVER FUND SCANDAL AND MAYOR

AKP lawmaker Serkan Bayram publicly criticized the massive investment fund scandal and the detention of opposition mayors. Questioning allegations involving **former minister Fatma Betül Sayan Kaya**, he demanded accountability for everyone implicated, including government officials. Condemning early-morning detentions of elected mayors, Bayram asked, “Why detain them when they would come if summoned?” He warned that without justice, investor confidence would collapse. His remarks sparked sharp criticism from pro-government figures, exposing tensions within the ruling party.



BAR PRESIDENT ADMITS MINISTRY GRANTED SPECIAL PRIVILEGES

Ankara’s No. 2 Bar Association President Gökhan Ağdemir publicly acknowledged that 70 lawyers from his association became judges or prosecutors over two years through referrals and discussions with government ministries. “The ministry granted us special privileges,” Ağdemir stated during a live broadcast. His remarks sparked criticism from the opposition YENİ Party, whose parliamentary deputy group leader described the association as a “bar with guaranteed judicial appointments.” The revelations raised serious questions about merit, transparency, and political influence in Türkiye’s judiciary.



TURKISH COMEDIAN DEFENDS FREE SPEECH AFTER IMPRISONMENT

Turkish comedian Deniz Göktaş, jailed for three months and sentenced to 19 months for “insulting the president,” spoke to The New York Times following his release. Göktaş said he never regretted his jokes, despite previously practicing self-censorship. “You can speak freely. You don’t have to be afraid,” he declared. Reflecting on Türkiye’s declining tolerance for political satire, he added, “If leaders can be so vulnerable to jokes, it is a sign of the power of comedy.”



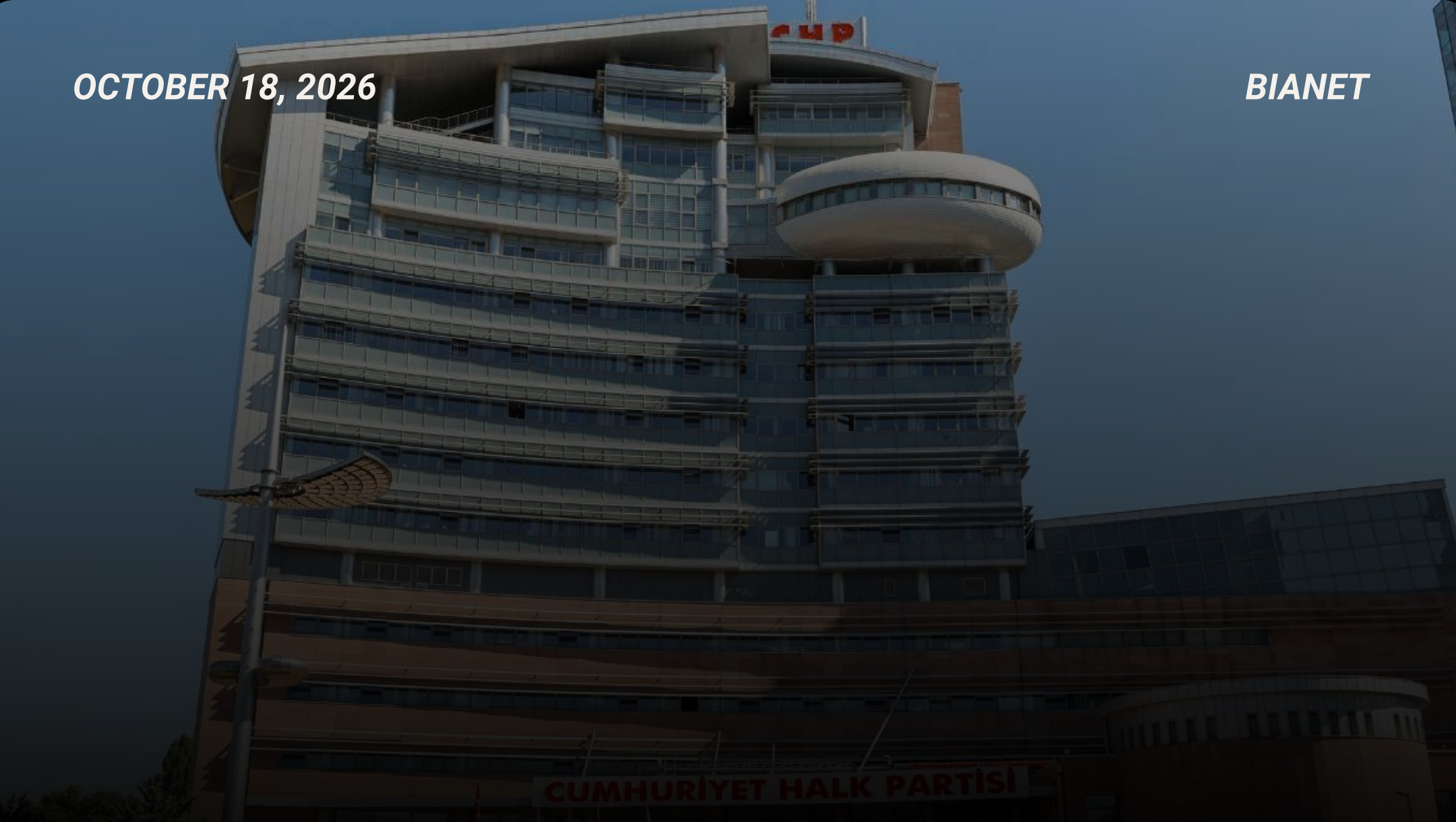
“ERDOĞAN MUST RESIGN”: OPPOSITION LEADERS UNITE

YENİ Party leader Özgür Özel met with Workers’ Party of Türkiye (TİP) leader Erkan Baş to discuss the country’s political turmoil and the ongoing investment fund scandal. Özel thanked TİP for its solidarity during difficult times. Questioning President Erdoğan’s response to the scandal, Baş asked how a leader could claim to govern Türkiye while allegedly failing to recognize massive corruption involving senior party officials, ministers, and deputy ministers. The meeting highlighted growing opposition criticism of the government’s handling of the scandal.



ACTRESS BERNA LAÇIN DETAINED OVER SOCIAL MEDIA POST, THEN RELEASED

Turkish actress Berna Laçin was detained on October 7 over a social media post following İzmir Mayor Cemil Tugay's decision to join the ruling AKP. "İzmir has been occupied before. Don't be afraid!" she wrote. Prosecutors accused her of "inciting hatred and hostility" under Article 216 of the Turkish Penal Code. Laçin denied wrongdoing, explaining that her words referred to İzmir's history. "I am being detained unlawfully," she stated. Despite prosecutors seeking her arrest, a court ordered her release.
ning.



CHP EXPELS 48 MEMBERS AMID DEEPENING PARTY SPLIT

Istanbul experienced its heaviest rainfall since 1942 on October 15, with some areas receiving 272 millimeters of rain. At least four people died, including a worker who fell into a well during floodwater drainage operations in Beykoz. Five others were reported missing as search efforts continued. Emergency teams rescued 3,050 people trapped by rising waters, while seven injured residents received medical treatment. Schools were closed on October 16, and authorities announced financial assistance for flood victims.

RESOURCES

- https://www.cumhuriyet.com.tr/siyaset/akp-li-serkan-bayram-in-fon-vurgunu-ve-operasyon-isyani-kizdirdi-ak-parti-ye-sizmis-truva-ati-olabilir-2543336
- https://bianet.org/haber/berna-lacin-serbest-birakildi-324234
- https://medyascope.tv/2026/10/08/ozgur-ozel-erkan-bas-ile-bir-araya-geldi-erdogan-istifa-etmeli/
- https://www.bbc.com/turkce/articles/cwvg0e409xp3o
- https://www.birgun.net/haber/ankara-2-nolu-baro-baskani-ndan-itiraf-bakanlik-bize-ayricalik-tanidi-70-uyemizi-hakim-savci-yaptik-739796
- https://bianet.org/haber/deniz-goktas-the-new-york-timesa-konustu-bir-an-bile-pismanlik-duymadim-324309
- https://www.dw.com/tr/osman-kavalan%C4%B1n-tahliye-ve-yeniden-yarg%C4%B1lama-talebi-reddedildi/a-79653669
- https://medyascope.tv/wp-content/uploads/2026/10/gazeteci-yazar-bahadir-ozgur-e-tck-301den-dava.jpg.webp
- https://bianet.org/haber/rojin-kabais-sorusturmasinda-2-yillik-cevapsiz-sorular-323804
- https://bianet.org/haber/istanbul-selde-can-kaybi-4-e-yukseldi-5-kisi-de-kayip-324464
- https://bianet.org/haber/chpde-48-kisi-ihrac-edildi-324488
- https://amp.dw.com/tr/halk-tv-%C3%A7al%C4%B1%C5%9Fanlar%C4%B1ndan-mesaj-susturamad%C4%B1klar%C4%B1-i%C3%A7in-el-koydular/a-79661400?utm
- https://bianet.org/haber/ege-universitesinde-polis-baskiniyla-toplanan-yaklasik-200-kopek-nereye-goturuldu-324542
- https://www.evrensel.net/haber/6005413/cemaat-isletti-akp-korudu-14-yasindaki-mahmut-u-ismailaga-nin-kacak-otoparki-oldurdu
- https://www.evrensel.net/haber/6005425/izmir-halkindan-eu-deki-kopeklerin-toplatilmasina-tepki